Atari User Guide Markdown Project

The Audience

This guide is for someone inheriting an old computer, peripherals, software, manuals, books, and more, who is familiar with modern computers.

The Goal

I had created a user guide before learning Technical Writing. I wanted to rewrite the guide using Technical Writing principles and also learn Markdown. The goal was to make a clear, step-by-step user guide for hardware setup, basic OS commands, and troubleshooting.

Constraints and Challenges

Challenge 1: Learning Markdown. I had no prior experience with Markdown, but I was familiar with tags from prior work with HTML and XML.
Challenge 2: Images. Some images are online, but I also had to take some of my own. I later learned that Markdown avoids using images, but these are supplemental to the text.
Challenge 3: Using Aging Technology. I had to consider that the user might be unfamiliar with tasks common when this computer was made, like playing a cassette tape, inserting a floppy disk, or understanding older tech nuances such as drive lettering and device management through selective power.

Tools

While not an industry standard, I found the MacDown 3000 application (https://macdown.app/) was perfect for this. It's a WYSIWYG side-by-side Markdown editor.

Results

See for yourself.

Here's the live guide: Atari Home Computer and Peripherals User Guide

Side-By-Side Comparison

The History section before:

History

It seemed proper to provide some background on the Atari and the times in which the Atari computer was created. Some of the software titles in my collection will make a little more sense if you understand what was happening during the time the Atari computer was popular. I also wanted to provide some history of this particular computer, for posterity and because it has a unique configuration.

At one time computers were people, mathematicians who did computation for a living. When we started to tackle the problem of sending man to the moon, hardware computers were in use but were very limited in capability. The phone you have in your hand today is a computer with greater capability and capacity than the computers that sent man to the moon. In 1975 hobbyists started to tinker with solid state CPUs. These hobbyists would gather to share their information with each other, help solve problems and grew as a community. Homebrew computing became a reality, but wasn't something most people would do. In 1976 Apple introduced the first Apple I computer you could buy as a kit. It came without a case or display. The hobbyist would supply those. It was very bare bones and not made for the masses. Apple and some others began to think perhaps there was a mass market for computers, but they needed to be more user friendly.

When I grew up, it was an analog world. We had rotary phones. Touch tone dialing wasn't even a thing. There was no cable TV. We had three analog television stations to choose from (ABC, NBC, CBS) and at some point we got a fourth (PBS). Television was broadcast on two bands, very high frequency (VHF) and ultra high frequency (UHF). Citizen Band radio (CBs) became popular for a time and allowed people at home to communicate via radio signals mostly with truckers and other hobbyists who got into CB radios. Home computers started to have mass appeal in the late 1970s. Apple introduced the Apple II computer in 1977 which included a case and was one of the first in the home market. Atari introduced the Atari 400 in 1979. And there were others such as Commodore, Amiga, and RadioShack's TRS-80 to name a few. Each one had its own unique operating systems and software. A game that worked on your Commodore computer wouldn't work on your friend's Apple II unless they got the Apple II version of it.

Before the internet, there were Bulletin Board Systems people could connect to. You would use a modem and dial into a "board" where if you were lucky you could text chat with the system operator (sysop) who would grant you access to files you could download shared by them or others members of the board. There was no cost for membership, but depending on the location of the board you might be charged for a long distance call. The first modems were 300 baud and then gradually increased in speed. At 300 baud, you could literally read the text on the screen as it was transmitted from the computer at the other end. File transfers over the phone at 300 baud took a while and people welcomed the increase in speed from 1200 baud and later 2400. However, the faster the modem, the more you'd pay for the device and the computer you would connect to would also require a modem equally as fast or faster because your connection was only as fast as the slower device on either end. This was one of only 4 ways you could obtain software for your computer. The other ways were to purchase it from a computer store, copy software from a friend if you could overcome any copy protection that might be on the software, or programming it yourself.

My grandfather was a self taught broadcast engineer who worked for NBC. He had taught himself several languages and to play a variety of musical instruments. When I was a kid, it seemed like there

The History section now:

A Brief History

Early Personal Computing

Understanding the Atari's roots makes its software and quirks more fun.

Computing in the 1970s–1980s

- Early computers were massive and expensive (e.g., those for the Apollo moon missions).
- Home computers started as kits for hobbyists who built them, like the Apple I.
- Atari released the Atari 400 in 1979—a colorful, game-friendly home computer with custom graphics chips.
- Rivals included Commodore, TRS-80, and Apple II. Each had unique software—no cross-compatibility.
- Pre-internet: Software came via stores, friends' copies, typing from magazines, or BBS (Bulletin Board Systems) via slow 300 baud modems (dial-up over phone lines).

Your Atari's Story

This Atari 400 started as a gift in the early 1980s. It began with 16K of RAM (16 kilobytes of random access memory) and no peripherals. Upgrades include:

- MOSAIC Memory Board: Boosts RAM to 48K.
- Custom composite video mod: For sharper output (metal top black box with DB-25 connector).
- Pull-out keyboard: From an Atari 1200XL, connects via ribbon cable.
- INDUS GT Disk Drive: Includes an add-on Z80 card.
- Atari 1050 Disk Drive: Includes an Archiver upgrade.
- ATR8000: Upgraded to 64K of RAM.

> **Note:** Both the original membrane keyboard and the custom keyboard can operate simultaneously.

There's also an unconnected Atari 800XL for 64K-only software (e.g., The Eidolon).

Life Before the Internet

Software was obtained in four primary ways:

- Purchased from a computer store
- Copied from a friend (if copy protection allowed)
- Typed in from magazines
- Downloaded via Bulletin Board Systems (BBS) using a modem

Early modems operated at 300 baud. Later speeds increased to 1200 and 2400 baud. Connections were made over telephone lines, often incurring long-distance charges.

- Overly wordy with too much background
- Lacks structure
- Assumes reader familiarity with terms

- Clean structured format
- Concise, relevant information
- Includes a glossary of terms